

Alternative Past

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Abstract

Image and text productions were once complex tasks that were inaccessible to most people. Today, the rise of generative AI has democratized the ability to alter both text and images. These AI-modified images can influence and even distort human memory, creating and amplifying alternative realities. So, what does it mean to reimagine the past with AI? How will AI interpret and reconstruct human memory, and might it offer comfort or something else?

Alternative Past is an AI-driven interactive installation that invites participants to share stories alongside images. The AI interprets these multimodal narratives, imagines, and processes both story and image to generate new historical artifacts, reconstructing a speculative past. Not as explicit editing instructions, but as personal, emotional storytelling. The transformed images are then extended into dynamic Fumage-like visuals, emphasizing the fluidity in memories and realities while offering a space of ambiguous imagination to the participants. Confronted with this alternative version of their own history, participants are prompted to reflect: "Could this be me?" or "What if things had happened this way?"

By granting the machine autonomy over personal stories and images, this work functions as a prism, refracting personal stories into nonlinear and non-subjective retelling. It promotes speculation on alternate self-identities and histories, reflection on the meaning of images, and discussions on AI autonomy through a playful experience.

In this work, the machine is no longer a detached tool or image processor, but a co-creator, emotionally entangled with human narratives. By treating memory as fluid and collaborative, it prompts us to re-examine ourselves and ask: When machines dream of our pasts, do we awaken differently?



Figure 1: *Alternative Past*, an interactive installation converting participants' memory artifacts into generative dynamic Fumages where AI imagines and reconstructs alternative past reality from human narratives.

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